

Meteoric career

As the son of Irish immigrant parents, Sheridan had an astonishing rise in the Civil War that could not be ascribed to family or political connections, which was the case with a number of officers. The young lieutenant on the Western frontier was also distant from influential contacts and had very few friends. When war did come, he earned his promotions through performance. Though his first postings were as a quartermaster and commissary officer in St. Louis, his efficiency and naturally bellicose streak soon won him the colonelcy of the 2nd Michigan Cavalry. Sheridan then saw combat in most of the major encounters in the West: Perryville, Stones River, Chickamauga, Chattanooga. Grant was so impressed by his dash at Missionary Ridge in the victory at Chattanooga that he invited him east for the coming campaign against General Lee, appointing him the Army of the Potomac's chief of cavalry.



Sheridan's saber

The sword Sheridan carried was an ornate version of the 1840 model cavalry saber, nicknamed the "wristbreaker" because it was so heavy. The gilded scabbard is engraved with the names of the battles in which he fought.

Praise and controversy

To his admirers, Sheridan was "Grant's flail," smashing the Confederates from Yellow Tavern to the Shenandoah Valley, which he thoroughly scourged. The valley was also the scene of his greatest triumph: his 10-mile (16-km) ride from Winchester to Cedar Creek, during which he rallied his demoralized troops, reeling from a surprise attack, and turned the tide of battle. On arrival, he was surrounded by thousands of cheering men. George Armstrong Custer raced up, threw his arms around Sheridan's neck and, as Frank Burr of the 2nd Michigan Cavalry put it, "kissed him in the